Software Development Project 1

Welcome to the Software Development Project 1 course! 👋

Introduction to software development projects

- The learning objectives for this week are:
  - Knowing about the course contents, assessment and schedule
  - Knowing how software development is carried out in practice and what kind of common problem areas it has
  - Knowing what is agile software development
  - Knowing what is the software development lifecycle and how it fits the agile software development
  - Knowing what is Scrum and how it is related to the agile software development
  - Knowing how stakeholders' requirements are managed in agile software development

About the course

- So far during the studies we have mostly worked on fairly small applications by ourselves
- Different kinds of problems arise while we work on more complicated applications in a software development team
- These problems aren't only technical, the management of the **software development process** can be quite tricky
- During this course, we will learn how to manage the software development process and how to work as a member of a software development team
- We will learn these skills in practice by developing a software development project in a software development team consisting of 4-5 students

About the course

- Each team will be developing a **quiz management application**, aimed to help teachers creating educational quizzes for their students
- The final application will be a **full stack web application** in which a frontend communicates with a backend
- The implementation technologies of the application are **Spring Boot** (backend) and **React** (frontend)
- The development of the project is split into three two-week iterations called Sprints
- Each Sprint has high-level requirements, but teams **should make most of the technical decisions themselves**
- The teams will be assembled during the first week and the project starts on the second week of the course

Assessment

- The assessment is based on the **team's project** and the **personal contributions** of a team member
- The project assessment is based on the following aspects:
  - Technical implementation
  - Project management
  - Documentation
  - Following the schedule
- Based on these assessment criteria, the team receives a **project grade** (0-5)

Assessment

- Each team member’s personal assessment is based on the following aspects:
  - Activity in teamwork
  - Technical contributions
  - Project management and documentation contributions
  - Exercise submissions
- The personal assessment is done based on the teacher’s observations and peer reviews from the team members
- Each team member receives a **personal grade** (0-5) based on their personal efforts towards the project and individual exercises

Assessment

- The final grade (0-5) is composed of the project grade and the personal grade
- The following are necessary to pass the course:
  - At least 60% of first and second week’s exercises must be completed
  - Written peer review for each team member
  - Passing project and personal grade
  - Written final report

Schedule

- There are weekly sessions during which we will cover different topics
- **At least 50% session attendance** is required for a passing grade
- During the first two weeks, we will cover topics that are important to grasp before starting to work on the project
- The teams will start working on the project during the second week
- During the teamwork we will learn about new topics, but most importantly we will learn how to apply our knowledge in practice
- Both individual exercises and project exercises have **deadlines**
- The detailed schedule of topics and deadlines can be found on the course material's "Schedule" page

What makes a software development project?

- So far during your studies, you have mostly implemented software individually, following instructions that describe more or less precisely what you should build
- In the real world, software is developed in **software development projects**, where people with different skills, backgrounds, and responsibilities work together as a **software development team**
- Software development projects vary greatly in scope and complexity. Depending on the project's goals, budget, and resources, a project can last from a few months to several years

Software development serves the stakeholders' needs

- A software development project affects many people in different ways
- For example, the software's end users get to use features they desire and the customer gets financial value for the project they are funding
- The people or groups of people affected by a software development project are referred to as the software development project's **stakeholders**
- In addition to solving technical problems, software developers will increasingly need to **understand stakeholder needs and build the right product** by applying appropriate technical solutions to address those needs

Software development team

- A software development team is responsible for the outcome of the project
- It is a diverse and self-organized group of people consisting of not only technical people
- The team can consist for example of a representative of the end users (commonly referred to as a product owner), user-experience (UI) and user-interface (UX) designers and software developers
- The size of the team varies, but they commonly consist of fewer than 10 people
- So that a software development team can work together efficiently they need to follow a **common process** in their day-to-day work
- This process is referred to as a **software development process**

Problems with software development projects

- Developing software based on the stakeholders' needs in a software development team isn't simple and many things can (and often do) go wrong
- **Which problems do you think software development projects commonly have?** Are the problems technical such as programming errors or something else?

Problems with software development projects

- Based on a study conducted in 2022, **70% of software development problems are non-technical**. The three most common problems raised were:
  - **Management issues**: excessive product owners, unclear task descriptions, unrealistic schedules, and constantly changing requirements
  - **Miscommunication and lack of communication**: the development team interprets project requirements differently from what the client had in their mind
  - **Customer-related issues**: customers lack understanding of technical processes, leading to unrealistic expectations and tight deadlines that developers struggle to meet

Agile principles in software development

> *"able to move quickly and easily."* —Dictionary definition for the word *"agile"*

- The word *"agile"* is often used in many industries to describe the way of working in organizations
- The word is commonly used in a positive manner, for example, *"we are an agile organization"*, or *"we work in an agile manner"*
- In **agile software development**, the development process follows values and principles that have been found to lead to successful software development projects
- These values and principles have been constituted and written down as the **Manifesto for Agile Software Development** by famous software development pioneers

Manifesto for Agile Software Development

- The Manifesto for Agile Software Development describes the following values:
  - **Individuals and interactions over processes and tools**: people should communicate directly and work together effectively instead of relying too much on rigid processes or tools
  - **Working software over comprehensive documentation**: the main focus should be on delivering functioning software, while keeping documentation useful but not excessive.
  - **Customer collaboration over contract negotiation**: the team should work closely with the customer throughout the project instead of only following an initial agreement
  - **Responding to change over following a plan**: plans are important, but the team should be ready to adjust them when requirements or circumstances change

Agile principles in software development

> *"Responding to change over following a plan."* — Agile Manifesto

- One of the key values is the attitude towards **change**
- For example, there is often a need to change the software's requirements during the development process
- Agile software development process should welcome any kind of change with open arms
- That is, because change is inevitable and frequent in many business environments
- The Manifesto for Agile Software Development doesn't go into detail on how to actually implement these values in practice
- Different Agile software development process frameworks, such as **Scrum** and **SAFe** describe a detailed process that follows these values

Software development lifecycle

- It requires **different phases** to be completed so that an idea of what we can do with a software becomes an actual working software which provides the desired features
- The software development process is divided into different phases:
  1. Requirements phase
  2. Design phase
  3. Implementation phase
  4. Test phase
  5. Deployment phase
  6. Maintenance phase
- The phases are commonly performed in the mentioned order and the whole process is often called the **software development lifecycle**

Requirements phase

- In the **requirements phase**, the development team collects requirements from several stakeholders such as customers and end users
- Requirements describe the features and behaviors of a system from the user's perspective, focusing on **how users interact with it and the outcomes they want to achieve**
- For example, *"As a blog reader I want to browse list of blog posts of a blog so that I can find interesting posts to read"* could be a requirement for a blog application
- These requirements are commonly documented and managed in so-called *"backlogs"* which act as a prioritized list of work for the development team

Design phase

- In the **design phase**, the development team analyzes requirements and identifies the best solutions to create the software
- For example, they may consider integrating pre-existing modules, making technology choices, and identifying development tools
- During the design phase different kinds of documentation, such as architecture diagrams, are produced to support the **implementation phase**

Implementation phase

- In the **implementation phase**, the development team codes the product
- They analyze the requirements to identify smaller coding tasks they can do daily to achieve the final result
- The organization of the collaboration during the implementation phase requires the development team to carefully follow mutually agreed **process**
- The development team needs to use different kinds of tools to ease the collaboration, such as **version control tools**, which we will cover later

Test phase

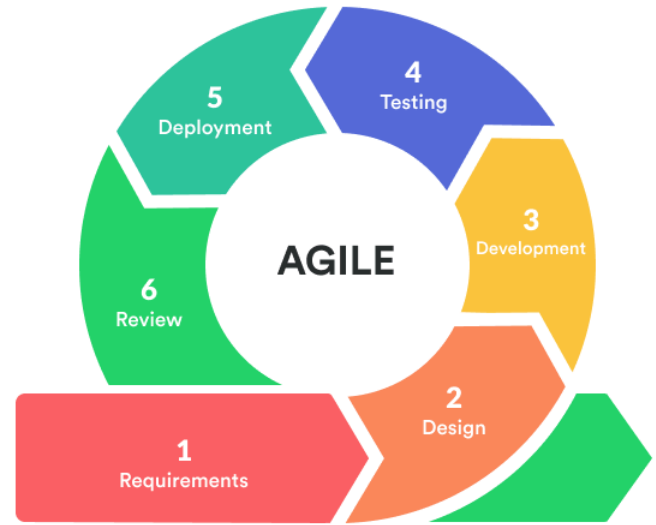
- In the **test phase**, the development team combines automation and manual testing to check that the software works as intended
- In practice, the test phase isn't usually separated from the implementation phase, but instead these phases **overlap**
- This means that software developers usually implement a small coding task, write automated test cases for the task and move on to the next task
- This practice is even taken so far that the tests are written **before** the implementation which is referred to as **test-driven development** (TDD)

Deployment and maintenance phase

- In the **deployment phase**, the implemented software is made accessible to the users
- For example, a web application is made available to users by deploying it to a server, allowing users to access it through their web browsers
- Once the software is distributed, it needs to be constantly **maintained**
- In the **maintenance phase**, among other tasks, the development team fixes bugs, resolves user issues, and manages software changes

Agile software development lifecycle

- Agile software development has an **iterative approach** in the software development lifecycle
- In this approach, the software is developed in short, typically one or two-week-long iterations
- Each iteration starts with the requirements phase and during the iteration design, implementation, test, deployment, and maintenance phases are completed
- The outcome of each iteration is working software that users can actually use and give feedback
- This cycle repeats in every iteration



Benefits of the iterative approach

> *"When to use iterative development? You should use iterative development only on projects that you want to succeed."* —Martin Fowler

- The benefits of the iterative approach are the **ability to respond to change quickly** and the feedback loop it provides
- After each iteration the requirements can change which makes it easy to respond to new user and business needs
- After each iteration the users of the software can get their hands on new features which they can give feedback on
- The feedback can be used to define requirements for the next iterations
- This forms the feedback loop which is the heartbeat of the agile software development process

Scrum

- **Scrum** is a widely adopted iterative software development process framework that defines practical ways to carry out agile software development principles
- Based on the State of Agile report of the year 2022, 87% of respondents used Scrum at the team level
- In the Scrum process, the **Scrum Team** develops software in fixed-length iterations called **Sprints**
- Sprints should be kept short, preferably at most four weeks long
- In each Sprint, there are fixed **events**, which help the Scrum Team organize their work and keep track of the progress of the Sprint
- During the course we will use Scrum to manage our software development process while working on the project

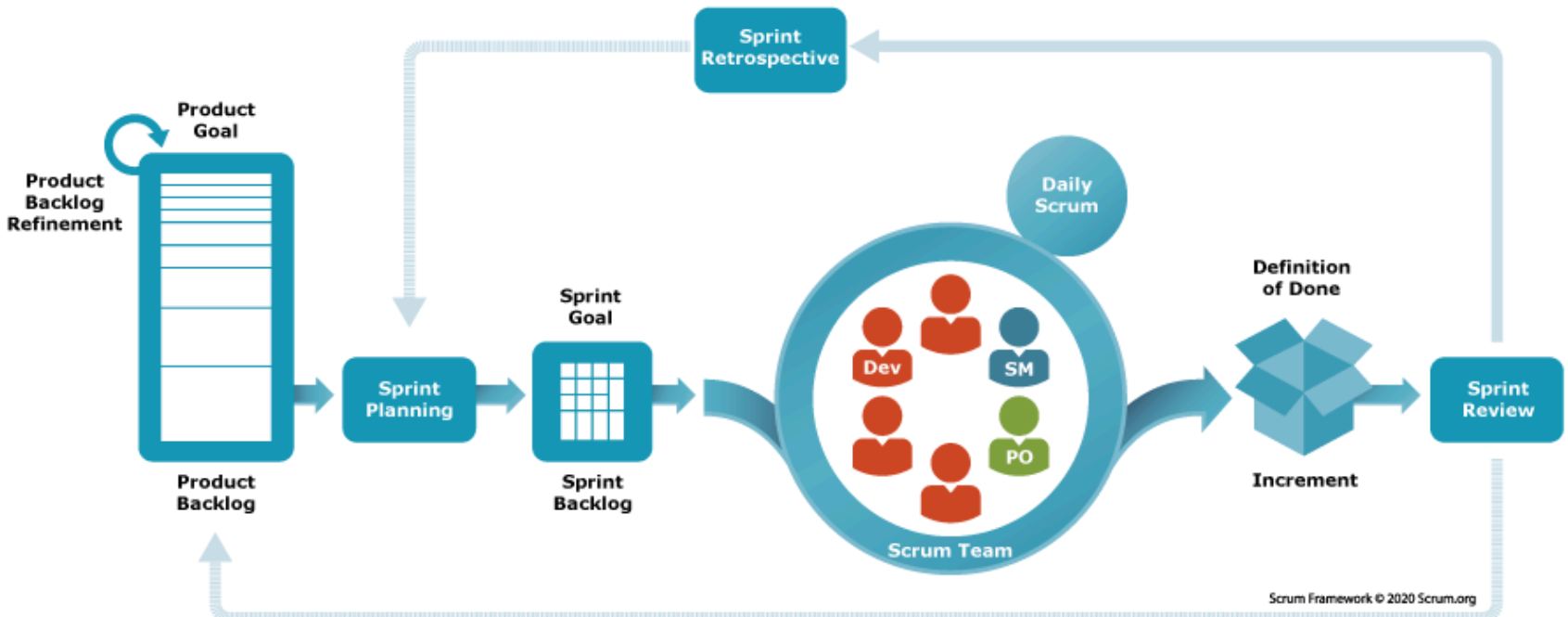
Scrum Team

- The **Scrum Team** is responsible for the outcome of each Sprint
- It consists of one **Scrum Master**, one **Product Owner**, and **Developers**
- To avoid coordination difficulties, the size of the Scrum Team should be fairly small, preferably at most 10 people
- **Developers** are responsible for the technical implementation of the software
- **Product Owner** is responsible for maximizing the value of the product resulting from the work of the Scrum Team
- **Scrum Master** is responsible for ensuring that the software development process follows the Scrum practices
- During the course, the teacher is the Product Owner and students are the Developers

Scrum Events

- Four *events* take place during each Sprint: **Sprint planning**, **Daily Scrum**, **Sprint Review** and **Retrospective**
- At the beginning of the Sprint, there's a **Sprint planning** event during which the Scrum Team decides which set of requirements are implemented during the upcoming Sprint
- During the Sprint, the Scrum Team organizes **Daily Scrum** meetings to discuss the progress of the Sprint
- At the end of the Sprint, there's a **Sprint Review** event during which the Scrum Team goes through the outcome of the Sprint
- Before starting the next Sprint, the Scrum Team discusses the problems with the process and figures out ways to improve it during the **Retrospective** event

The Scrum process



Requirements

- During the requirements phase, the stakeholders' requirements for the software are defined and documented
- To derive the requirements, the development team needs to have a clear and thorough understanding of the software under development and continuously communicate with the stakeholders
- Software's requirements are commonly categorized as **functional** and **non-functional requirements**
- Functional requirements describe **what the user can do with the software**, such as the features and functionality it must provide to its users
- Non-functional requirements describe the quality attributes and constraints the system must satisfy, such as performance, security, reliability, and usability

Functional and non-functional requirements

- For example the following requirements are **functional requirements**:
  - *"User should be able to register with a username and password"*
  - *"User should be able to see a list of latest blog posts of their favorite blogs"*
- And the following requirements are **non-functional requirements**:
  - *"User's password should be stored in the database as a Bcrypt password hash upon registration"*
  - *"List of latest blog posts of user's favorite blogs should be loaded on average in a less than one second"*

Agile requirement specification

- In agile software development, requirements are commonly written as **user stories**
- A user story is a short, simple description of a feature told from the perspective of the person who desires the new feature in the software
- During each Sprint, the Developers of the Scrum Team implement features for the software based on user stories
- User stories are sort of to-do items, which help the Scrum Team understand and remember what kind of features need to be implemented for the software
- **Use cases** are another, less Agile-friendly, way of defining requirements. They focus more on **how the system will work**, not **what the user needs**

User story

- For example, two separate user stories for a blog application could be the following:
  - *"As a content **creator**, I want to **create a new blog** so that **I can start writing blog posts**"*
  - *"As a blog **reader**, I want to **browse list of blog posts of a blog** so that **I can find interesting posts to read**"*
- A user story is written from the user's perspective and commonly follows the following format:

> As **[a user persona]**, I want **[to perform this action]** so that **[I can accomplish this goal]**.

Let’s write some user stories

- **Come up with and write down user stories in one or more applications you have used**, for example Netflix or Moodle
- Use the *"As [a user persona], I want [to perform this action] so that [I can accomplish this goal]"* format
- Try to come up with different user personas for the user stories
- Share your user stories with others and let’s discuss about them

Writing good user stories

- A good user story describes a **feature that provides value for the end user of the software**
- This means, that the description should be written from the user's perspective and not contain technical details
- For example the following user story is described from the developer's point of view:

> ❌ As a developer, I want to optimize the database by adding a new index to the blog posts table so that the list of blog posts of a blog loads fast.

- A better user story would express the feature from the user's point of view:

> ✅ As a blog reader, I want the list of blog posts of a blog load fast so that I can find interesting blog posts to read quickly.

The INVEST criteria

- The **INVEST criteria** is one popular guideline for a good user story:
  - **Independent**: written so they can be developed and tested independently of other stories
  - **Negotiable**: written to allow for negotiation between the development team and the customer
  - **Valuable**: should provide value to the end user.
  - **Estimable**: written in a way that allows the development team to estimate the amount of effort required to complete them
  - **Small**: small enough to be completed within a single iteration of the development process
  - **Testable**: written to allow testing to be performed at the end of the development process

The INVEST criteria

- Which INVEST criteria (independent, negotiable, valuable, small, testable) does the following user story violate?

> ❌ As a blog reader, I want to be able to search blog posts by name, category and author so that I can find relevant blog posts to read

The INVEST criteria

- It is better to split these kinds of big user stories into multiple smaller user stories:

> ✅ As a blog reader, I want to be able to search blog posts by name so that I can find relevant blog posts to read
>
> ✅ As a blog reader, I want to be able to search blog posts by category so that I can find relevant blog posts to read
>
> ✅ As a blog reader, I want to be able to search blog posts by author so that I can find relevant blog posts to read

- This allows faster delivery and feedback and lower risks of requirement misunderstandings and technical issues

- If the description of the feature contains words like *"and"* or *"or"*, it could be that the user story can be split into smaller user stories